

I. THE GREEN DOOR

Mr. Aldous Penrose discovered a green door behind the ivy on the east wall of his garden. The door had no handle and no keyhole, only a small brass plate engraved with a crescent moon. He pressed his palm against the cool wood and felt a faint vibration, as though something on the other side was breathing in time with him. For three nights he returned, and on the third the door opened of its own accord.

II. THE CLOCKMAKER OF VENN

The clockmaker of Venn was famous for building timepieces that ran backward. Travelers came from distant provinces to watch the hands of his great hall clock sweep counter to the sun. He claimed that a clock running backward did not measure lost time but recovered it, and that anyone who watched long enough would remember a day they had forgotten. The mayor of Venn forbade the clock, fearing the townsfolk would stop working.

III. THE LANTERN TIDE

Once a year the harbor of Saltmere filled with floating lanterns, each carrying a written wish from a villager. The tide pulled them out past the breakwater and, it was said, delivered them to the drowned city beneath the waves. Young Mira wrote her wish on rice paper and folded it into a paper boat shaped like a swan. She wished not for herself but for the lighthouse keeper, who had not smiled since the winter his daughter was lost at sea.